DIGITALAIKART ORIGINAL

THE EV CHARGING STATION BUSINESS PLAYBOOK

2026-27 · INDIA EDITION

Site, machine, permissions, power and the numbers — everything you need to decide whether an EV charging station in India will pay you back, before you spend the first rupee.

52,718 public charging stations · 8.27% EV penetration · a median charger busy 8.7% of the day

The Honest Pitch

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PART ONE

The Honest Picture

What this business is, what it is not, and the one number that decides whether your station ever pays you back.

1. What you are actually selling

Walk into any EV charging stall in India and you will see a machine, a cable, and a driver waiting. It looks like a petrol pump with a plug. It is not. A petrol pump sells a product it bought and marked up. A charging station sells a service, and the electricity it uses is consumed inside its own premises. That single legal detail shapes everything that follows: your tax rate, your licence status, your tariff, and the ceiling on what you may charge.

The Ministry of Power settled this in its clarification of April 2018 and the GST authorities confirmed it in 2023. Charging a battery is not the sale of electricity. It is a service that consumes electricity. The Karnataka Authority for Advance Rulings, in order KAR ADRG 24/2023 dated 13 July 2023, held that the whole amount a customer pays at a public charging station, energy component included, is a composite supply of service under SAC 998714, taxable at 18 per cent.

Three practical consequences, before you spend a rupee:

- You do not need a distribution licence under the Electricity Act, 2003. The Ministry of Power's 2024 guidelines call setting up and operating a charging station a de-licensed activity. Any entity may do it.
- Your customer pays 18 per cent GST on the full bill. Your electricity bill from the DISCOM is your input, not a resale, and the tariff you are charged is a special EV tariff, not a commercial one.
- Your price has a legal ceiling until 31 March 2028: the electricity tariff you pay, plus a service charge capped per unit, plus land cost, plus GST. Chapter 21 works through the arithmetic.

The second thing to understand is that you are not in the electricity business. You are in the parking-and-patience business. A 60 kW charger delivers roughly 40 kWh in a 40-minute stop, which is about 200 km of range for a mid-size electric car. The driver has 40 minutes to fill. Whatever you put in that 40 minutes, a chai counter, a clean toilet, a shaded seat, a shop, is where the margin and the repeat visit live. Stations that treat the wait as dead time lose the customer to the station 4 km ahead that does not.

> **The sentence to keep on your desk**
> A charging station is a real-estate and footfall business wearing an electrical engineering costume. The machine is the easy part. The site is the business.

2. Where India's electric fleet actually is

You cannot size a charging business on headlines. You need the shape of the fleet, because the shape decides which charger you buy. Here is the shape, from Vahan registration data as reported through 2026.

Segment	FY2025-26 units	Share of EV sales	EV penetration in its segment
Electric two-wheelers	14.02 lakh	57%	6.5% of all two-wheelers
Electric three-wheelers	8.31 lakh	34%	61% of all three-wheelers
Electric cars (e-4W)	1.99 lakh	8%	about 6% of car sales in Jan-Jul 2026
Electric commercial vehicles	19,648	0.8%	under 1%

Total: about 24.5 lakh EVs in FY2025-26, which was 8.27 per cent of all vehicles registered that year. The Ministry of Heavy Industries puts EV adoption at 8.26 per cent for FY2025-26, up from 0.08 per cent in FY2015-16. Growth has not stopped: October 2026 alone saw 3,54,284 EV registrations, and the twelve months to October 2026 came to 33.3 lakh units. EVs were 10.7 per cent of all vehicle sales in calendar 2026 so far, against 8 per cent in 2025.

Now read that table again with a charger in mind. Roughly 91 per cent of India's electric vehicles are two- and three-wheelers. Their batteries are small, between about 2 and 8 kWh. They charge slowly, often for an hour or more, and they charge near home, near work, or at a stand where the driver waits for a fare. A 60 kW CCS2 car charger, the machine most business plans are built around, cannot serve any of them.

This is the most common and most expensive mistake in the sector: buying the charger the industry talks about rather than the charger your street needs. Chapter 13 is entirely about matching the machine to the mix outside your gate.

> **The ratio worth knowing**
> 52,718 public charging stations existed in India as of 21 July 2026, of which 16,561 had fast chargers for cars, according to the Ministry of Heavy Industries as reported by PIB. Against roughly one crore EVs registered since 2017, that is about 190 EVs per public charging point and about 600 per fast car charger. The network is thin. Thin networks and idle chargers exist at the same time, which is the paradox the next chapter explains.

3. Fifty-two thousand chargers, and a utilisation problem

If you read only one chapter of this playbook twice, read this one. It is the difference between a station that earns and a station that sits.

Utilisation is the share of time a charger is actually delivering paid energy. A charger in use for two hours out of twenty-four runs at 8.3 per cent utilisation. Everything in your profit and loss is a function of that number, and it is the one thing vendors never put in their brochure.

The published estimates are consistent and uncomfortable:

- An SBI report on e-mobility and charging infrastructure (April 2026) put utilisation at most Indian charging stations at 1 to 3 per cent.
- S&P; Global estimated around 5 per cent in 2024.
- A charge-point operator tracking 1,745 public DC stations across India over the 30 days to 1 November 2026 reported a median of 8.7 per cent, about two hours a day. One station in four was above 24 per cent. The busiest tenth were above 48 per cent.
- The same tracking found the typical station out of action about 2 per cent of the time, but the average station was down more than 10 per cent, because a minority of sites stay broken for weeks.

Put those side by side and the sector's real story appears. The median station is idle 91 per cent of the day. The top quarter are busy six hours a day. The top tenth are busy eleven. Same country, same chargers, same tariffs. The difference is the site and the uptime.

This is also why the big operators lose money. Tata Power's EZ Charge and Statiq, two of the most visible public networks, posted combined losses above Rs 1,000 crore across FY2024 and FY2025 while their installed capacity nearly tripled. Chargers went up. Paid units barely moved.

For you, as a small operator, this is not a reason to stay out. It is a reason to be selective in a way the large networks cannot be, because you are choosing one site and they are choosing a thousand. You can afford to walk away from a bad site. They mostly cannot.

> **The viability line**
> Operators and analysts put the unit-economics floor at roughly 18 to 20 per cent utilisation for a capex-funded public DC station. Below that, payback stretches past the reasonable life of the asset. Above 25 per cent, the business is genuinely good. Your entire pre-investment job is to find evidence that a specific site can clear 18 per cent, not to hope it will.

4. Four ways people make money here, and one that mostly does not

There is no single EV charging business. There are four, with different capital, different risk and very different odds.

Model 1: The host

You own the land, the parking, the shop or the fuel pump. Someone else pays for the charger. You take a share of every unit sold, typically Rs 1 to Rs 3 per kWh, or a fixed monthly fee, or both. Capital at risk: close to zero. This is the safest position in the entire value chain and it is available to a surprising number of people: petrol pump owners, mall and hotel owners, marriage halls, hospitals, dhabas on a highway, gated societies with 400 flats.

Bolt.Earth built a national network on exactly this logic. Its chief executive told Business Standard in November 2025 that a typical four-wheeler DC installation costs Rs 10 to 15 lakh and takes 8 to 12 years for a charge point operator to pay back, longer than the equipment's life, and that the company instead sells chargers to hosts who earn from every session. Their network average utilisation was around 18 to 20 per cent, because a host only buys when there are already EVs at the gate.

Model 2: The owner-operator

You buy the machine, take the connection, run the site. Full upside, full downside. This is the model this playbook is mostly about, because it is the one you can start from a standing position with Rs 12 to 20 lakh and one good site. It works when utilisation clears 18 per cent. It destroys capital when it does not.

Model 3: The fleet contractor

You install chargers inside someone else's depot, e-cab company, e-rickshaw fleet, delivery fleet, school bus operator, and sell energy by contract at a fixed rate per unit with a minimum monthly offtake. Utilisation is contracted rather than hoped for. Margins are thinner per unit, often Rs 4 to Rs 7, but the volume is predictable and the payback is bankable. For a first station, this is the most underrated route in India.

Model 4: The landlord of power

You own the connection and the meter, and sub-meter to several operators or hawkers. Rare, regulated, and not worth the complexity for a first venture. Mentioned for completeness.

The one that mostly does not work

Buy a 60 kW DC charger, install it on a quiet plot on the edge of a tier-2 city because land was cheap, price at Rs 18 a unit, and wait for the EVs to arrive. The plot was cheap because nobody drives there. This is the modal failure in the sector and it fails slowly, over three years, while the EMI runs.

5. The one question that decides everything

Before the vendor, before the loan, before the subsidy application, answer this in numbers:

> *How many electric vehicles will pass within 500 metres of this gate on a normal Tuesday, and how many of them will need to charge today?*

If you cannot answer with a count you have personally observed, you do not have a business plan. You have an intention. Chapter 7 shows you how to get that count in three visits, with a notebook and a phone camera, for the price of the fuel.

The rest of this playbook assumes you will do that work. It is organised in the order you will actually spend money: site, then machine, then permissions and power, then the numbers, then operations. Parts Six and Seven are the parts you will keep coming back to once the station is live.

6. Ten beliefs that cost people money

Every one of these is something a prospective operator has said to me or written in a forum. Each has a correction that is worth lakhs.

1. "EV sales are growing 40 per cent a year, so demand is guaranteed"

Demand at the national level is not demand at your gate. EV sales grew 25 per cent in FY2025-26 and the penetration reached 8.27 per cent, but that growth is concentrated in two- and three-wheelers, in specific cities and along specific corridors. Your site either sits on one of those flows or it does not.

2. "A 60 kW charger gives 60 kW to every car"

Almost no car takes 60 kW for the whole session. It tapers as the battery fills, and many Indian EVs peak well below 60 kW. Plan on 35 to 45 kW average, which is what every model in this playbook assumes.

3. "The subsidy will cover a big chunk of my capex"

State subsidies are capped, rationed by station count and paid after commissioning and verification. PM E-DRIVE, the big central scheme, is not open to private owners at all. Treat a subsidy as a bonus that improves your payback, never as the reason the project works.

4. "Cheap land means cheap entry"

Cheap land is usually cheap because nobody drives past it. Land is 5 to 10 per cent of your project cost and 100 per cent of your demand. Paying more for frontage is almost always the better trade.

5. "A bigger charger earns more"

A bigger charger earns more only if vehicles arrive that can accept the power. A 120 kW unit on a street where e-rickshaws charge is a 120 kW space heater. Match the machine to the fleet.

6. "GST on charging is 5 per cent, like EVs"

EVs attract 5 per cent. Chargers attract 5 per cent. The charging service attracts 18 per cent, on the full value including the energy component, as the Karnataka AAR held in 2023. Getting this wrong on your invoices creates a liability that surfaces a year later.

7. "I will break even at 5 per cent utilisation because my costs are low"

At 5 per cent, a Rs 15 lakh station nets under Rs 1,000 a month in the model in Chapter 27. The fixed costs, rent, AMC, software and gateway, do not shrink with traffic. Low utilisation is not a low-cost state, it is a high-cost-per-unit state.

8. "The charger company will handle everything"

Vendors sell hardware and, sometimes, a CMS. They do not find your site, negotiate your lease, obtain your fire NOC, chase your DISCOM, or answer a driver at 10 pm. Some offer a franchise that looks like it does all this; read the revenue share and the exit terms very carefully before signing one.

9. "Once it is installed, it runs itself"

The average public DC station in India was out of action more than 10 per cent of the time in the 30 days to 1 November 2026. Stations do not run themselves. Somebody checks the guns, resets the unit, cleans the screen and replaces the cable.

10. "I will figure out the numbers after I open"

You will not. The numbers are the decision. Everything in Part Five can be done on one sheet of paper before you sign a lease, and the site scorecard in Chapter 8 takes an afternoon. There is no version of this business where opening first and modelling later works out.

PART TWO

The Site

Site selection is 80 per cent of the outcome. This part gives you a repeatable way to test a location before you commit capital.

7. The four site types that clear viability

Across the operator data, four site types repeatedly clear the 18 per cent line. Everything else is a lottery.

Site type	Why it works	Typical utilisation	What it needs
Captive fleet depot	Vehicles return to the same place every night by contract. Demand is scheduled, not hoped for.	25-45%	A fleet agreement, 8-15 year lease or in-depot space, high-power DC
High-traffic highway forecourt	Long-distance drivers must stop. 20-45 minutes of dwell time, no alternative nearby.	15-30%	Highway frontage, food and toilets, 2+ DC guns, signage visible at speed
Premium urban destination	Malls, hospitals, hotels, offices: the car parks anyway, the driver shops anyway.	10-20%	Host partnership, AC plus one DC, clear bay marking, valet coordination
Dense two/three-wheeler catchment	E-rickshaw stands, delivery hubs, market roads, dense rental housing.	20-40% (small units)	Low capex, many small points, LEV DC or AC, an attendant

The pattern behind all four: demand is either contractual (fleet), forced (highway), or already present for another reason (destination, dense catchment). Nowhere does the site depend on someone changing their route to find you.

The site types that fail: empty plots on bypass roads, industrial areas with no night traffic, new townships where the EV count is still in single digits, and any location where the nearest competitor is 30 km away because there is nothing there.

8. Counting demand without a survey company

You need three numbers: how many EVs pass, what kind, and how often they would stop. Get them by hand over three days, one weekday, one Saturday, one Sunday, at the hours that matter.

1. Stand at the gate for two hours in the morning peak (8 to 10 am) and two in the evening (5 to 8 pm). Count every electric two-wheeler, e-rickshaw, e-car and e-bus that passes. A tally counter on your phone is enough.
2. Photograph number plates of e-rickshaws and e-cabs. In a month, repeat plates tell you the same vehicles circulate locally, which is good news: local circulation is repeat custom.
3. Find the nearest three public charging points on the government EV Yatra portal and on Google Maps. Visit them. Note how many cars are plugged in, at what time, and what they pay. If a nearby station is full at 7 pm, demand exceeds supply within 3 km and you have found something.
4. Ask the auto and taxi stands, the e-rickshaw union, the delivery hub manager, the nearest car dealership's EV salesperson. The dealership knows exactly how many EVs it has sold in that pin code in the last year. Ask for the number, not an opinion.
5. Check the local DISCOM's EV load. A subdivision engineer can tell you how many EV connections exist in the area. Twenty connections in a 2 km radius is a working market.

Then convert. A useful rule of thumb for a car DC site: if 150 electric cars pass your gate in a day and 6 per cent stop to charge, that is 9 sessions. At 30 kWh per session that is 270 kWh a day, roughly 8,100

a month. On a 60 kW machine that is about 11 per cent utilisation, which is above the median but below the viability line. You now know, before spending, that this site needs either more traffic or a fleet contract.

> **The 6 per cent rule**
> In most Indian cities, roughly 4 to 8 per cent of passing EVs stop at a given public charger on a given day. Use 6 per cent as a planning number, then check it against the neighbouring station's occupancy. If your model needs 15 per cent of passing EVs to stop, the site is wrong, not the price.

9. The site scorecard

Score every candidate site out of 100 before you negotiate anything. Below 60, walk away. Between 60 and 75, only proceed with a fleet contract. Above 75, negotiate hard and move fast.

Test	What good looks like	Points
EV traffic past the gate	40+ electric cars or 300+ electric two/three-wheelers in a 12-hour day	20
Dwell reason	Food, toilets, shop, office, market, or a fleet that parks here	15
Grid strength	Existing LT supply within 100 m; transformer capacity available	15
Visibility and access	Seen from the road, easy in and out, no blocking	10
Land cost	Under Rs 15,000 a month, or a revenue share under Rs 2/unit	10
Competition	No working DC charger within 3 km, or one that is full at peak	10
Host willingness	Owner will sign 5+ years and share maintenance	10
Night use	Fleet, cab or commercial vehicles that charge after 9 pm	10

The night-use row is the one most people skip. A station that sells only to private cars during the day loses half its potential. A station that also serves e-cabs, delivery vans or a bus fleet after dark has two demand curves, and the second one usually comes with a contract.

10. City, highway, depot, destination: what each one needs

The city site

Two to four guns, AC plus one DC, inside a market or a busy commercial street. The competition is other chargers and the home socket, so your edge is convenience and reliability, not speed. Price at the market, display the tariff, and make payment work on the first attempt. City sites live and die on repeat visits from e-cabs and e-rickshaws, so treat those drivers as your primary customer, not the private car owner who charges twice a month.

The highway site

The Ministry of Power's 2024 guidelines envisage charging every 20 km on both sides of highways and expressways, and a fast-charging station every 100 km for long-range and heavy vehicles. Highway economics are the best in the country when the location is right, because the driver has no alternative and will pay for speed. It also has the highest capital requirement, the highest power requirement, and the most unforgiving uptime expectation: a dead charger 60 km from the next one is a customer lost for life and a review you cannot delete. Never open a highway site without remote monitoring and a local person who can reset it.

The depot

The most bankable and least glamorous. You sign an energy supply agreement with a fleet, install inside their yard, and get paid monthly on metered units with a minimum offtake clause. Capital is lower because the fleet usually provides the land and the parking. Your risk is counterparty risk, so check how long the fleet has been operating and insist on a security deposit of one month's average billing.

The destination

Malls, hospitals, hotels, airports, offices, large societies. Your revenue per unit is lower because the host takes a share, but the capex can be shared and the footfall is free. The trick is bay design: if an SUV parks in your charging bay and walks into the mall for three hours, your charger earns nothing and every EV driver behind them curses you. Marked bays, a 3-hour idle fee, and a host who enforces it are non-negotiable.

11. Land: buy, lease, or revenue share

Three structures, and the choice matters more than the rent.

Buy

Only if you already wanted the land for something else. A charging station does not justify land purchase in most Indian cities, because the payback on land is longer than the payback on steel.

Lease

A fixed monthly rent for 5 to 9 years with a 5 per cent annual escalation. Predictable, and it protects your upside if the site does well. Typical range for a two-bay site in a tier-1 city is Rs 10,000 to Rs 40,000 a month depending on frontage; highway frontage and mall parking run far higher. Insist on a lock-in of at least three years and a right of first refusal on renewal, because your charger is worth much less if you have to move it.

Revenue share

You pay the landowner a fixed amount per unit sold. This is the structure the government itself uses: the Ministry of Power's 2024 guidelines set Rs 1 per kWh as the floor for public land offered to private operators on bid, with a model 10-year agreement, and the same model is available to any private landowner who prefers it. A revenue share of Rs 1 to Rs 2 per unit is common; Rs 3 or more will eat your margin at low utilisation. The advantage is that it aligns incentives, the host wants your chargers working, and the disadvantage is that hosts underestimate how few units you will sell in year one and then feel cheated. Show them your volume model before signing.

The clause that saves you

Whatever the structure, put three things in writing: a 5-year minimum term with renewal at your option, the host's obligation to keep the bays clear of non-EV parking, and the right to remove your equipment if the site underperforms. Without the third, a bad site becomes a stranded asset.

12. The host conversation

If you are approaching a petrol pump, a mall, a dhaba or a society, here is what they actually want to know, in the order they will ask it.

1. What do I have to spend? Answer: nothing, or the civil work, depending on the deal.
2. What do I get? Answer: a number. Rs 1.50 per unit sold, or Rs 8,000 a month, or a share of the session fee. Give a range based on your own volume model, not a promise.
3. Who pays for the electricity? You do. Say it clearly, because the first fear is a surprise bill.
4. What happens to my parking? Two bays, marked, with a 3-hour idle fee so they turn over.
5. What if it does not work? You remove the equipment at your cost after 12 months. Put it in the contract.
6. Who handles complaints? You do, on a number displayed at the station. This is the answer that closes the deal, because the host does not want to explain a broken charger to a stranger.

Bring one page: a photo of a similar installation, your volume estimate, the revenue share, and the exit clause. Do not bring a 40-page proposal. The decision-maker is usually the owner, and the owner decides in one meeting.

PART THREE

The Machine

Connectors, real 2026 prices, the questions that separate a charger from a liability, and the electrical work that decides your uptime.

13. AC or DC, and the connector alphabet

Six terms cover almost everything you will hear from a vendor. Learn them once and the sales conversation changes completely.

Term	What it means	Where it fits
Type 2 AC	Alternating-current charging, typically 7.4 to 22 kW. Uses the on-board charger in the vehicle.	Cars parked for hours: offices, hotels, homes, societies
CCS2	Combined Charging System, DC fast. Indian standard IS 17017-2-3. 50 to 250 kW for cars, higher for buses and trucks.	Highway and city fast charging for cars, e-buses, e-trucks
LEV DC (IS 17017-2-6)	Light electric vehicle DC, up to 12 kW. The fast-charging standard for two- and three-wheelers.	E-rickshaw stands, delivery hubs, dense 2W/3W catchments
LEV AC/DC combo (IS 17017-2-7)	Up to 12 kW, accepts either light-EV AC or DC input.	Mixed two/three-wheeler sites
Bharat DC-001	An older Indian DC standard, 15 kW, still present on many e-rickshaws and small cars.	Legacy fleet support, not a primary choice in 2026
OCPP	Open Charge Point Protocol. The language your charger speaks to your software.	Non-negotiable. Buy OCPP 1.6J or 2.0.1 compliant hardware

The Ministry of Power's 2024 guidelines are deliberately flexible on station composition, but they do say one thing worth noting: for small EVs such as two-wheelers, three-wheelers, quadricycles and small four-wheelers, charge point operators should preferably provide a minimum 7.4 kW AC or DC charger. And for stations serving long-range and heavy-duty vehicles, at least two chargers of 240 kW each, at Power Level 3 or 4.

AC or DC is not a quality question, it is a dwell-time question. If the vehicle is going to be parked for two hours anyway, AC is cheaper, kinder to the battery and cheaper to install. If the driver is waiting, DC is the only thing that will hold them. Buying DC for a site where nobody is in a hurry is how people spend Rs 8 lakh to sell 60 units a day.

14. Match the charger to the fleet at your gate

India's EV fleet is roughly 57 per cent two-wheelers, 34 per cent three-wheelers and 8 per cent cars. Your site will not match the national average, but the national average tells you that the default assumption, a car fast charger, is wrong nine times out of ten.

What dominates your site	Buy this	Capex per point	Revenue per unit	Watch out for
E-rickshaws and e-carts	LEV DC 3.3-12 kW, or AC 3.3 kW with an attendant	Rs 25,000-1.2 lakh	Rs 12-15	Long queues at fixed times; add points, not power
Delivery and cab fleets	LEV DC 12 kW plus one CCS2 30-60 kW	Rs 1.2-8 lakh	Rs 14-20	Peak clustering 8-11 am and 6-10 pm
Private electric cars	CCS2 30-60 kW dual gun	Rs 6-9 lakh	Rs 16-22	Low utilisation unless on a route
Mixed market street	Two LEV DC 12 kW plus one CCS2 60 kW	Rs 8-12 lakh	Rs 14-22	Bay blocking by non-EVs

What dominates your site	Buy this	Capex per point	Revenue per unit	Watch out for
Buses or trucks	CCS2 120-240 kW	Rs 15-30 lakh	Rs 12-18	Contract required; do not build speculatively

One warning on dual-gun chargers. A 60 kW dual-gun unit with dynamic power sharing gives 60 kW to one vehicle or 30 kW to each of two. That is fine and honest, but if your site regularly has two cars waiting, you have bought a 30 kW station that can occasionally go faster. Size on the concurrent case, not the brochure case.

15. What the hardware actually costs in 2026

These are listed prices from Indian manufacturers and sellers, checked in November 2026. Treat them as the floor of a negotiation, not the ceiling, and remember that GST on chargers is 5 per cent, not 18.

Charger	Listed price	Notes
60 kW DC, dual CCS2 gun, Zevpoint Nova 60	Rs 5,69,000 ex-factory + 5% GST	ARAI certified, OCPP 1.6, needs about 67 kVA
60 kW DC, dual gun, Servotech	Rs 6,07,200	Listed online, hardware only
60 kW DC, dual gun, Bolt.Earth Lightning	Rs 6,09,999	Dynamic sharing, 2-year warranty
60 kW DC, single gun, Massive Charging MC-D060	Rs 8.2 lakh ex-works	OCPP 2.0.1
60 kW DC, dual gun, Havells MotrON	Rs 12,98,000 incl. taxes	Brand premium, service network
120 kW DC, dual gun, Servotech	Rs 8,10,640	Two 60 kW modules, power sharing
120 kW DC, dual gun, Charget	Rs 10,40,000	ISO 15118, OCPP 1.6J and 2.0.1
120 kW DC, dual gun, Havells MotrON	Rs 17,93,000 incl. taxes	Brand premium
7.4 kW AC wall unit	Rs 18,000-45,000	BIS certified, single phase or three phase
LEV DC 12 kW, two-wheeler and three-wheeler	Rs 90,000-1.8 lakh	Look for IS 17017-2-6 compliance

For comparison, the Bureau of Energy Efficiency's benchmark costs, published in August 2022 and still the basis on which PM E-DRIVE subsidy is calculated, are far below market: Rs 7.25 lakh for a 50 kW CCS2 charger and Rs 11.68 lakh for 100 kW, with upstream infrastructure at Rs 6.04 lakh up to 50 kW, Rs 14.80 lakh up to 100 kW, Rs 19 lakh up to 150 kW and Rs 24 lakh above that. If you ever apply for a subsidy, the lower of benchmark or actual cost is what gets counted, and that is why a heavily branded charger can reduce your effective subsidy.

16. Nine questions that separate a charger from a liability

Ask these in writing, and ask for the document, not the answer. A vendor who cannot produce them is telling you something.

1. Which Indian Standards does the unit conform to, and where is the type test certificate? Every charger should be type tested to the IS 17017 series, by an NABL-accredited laboratory, with a valid certificate. The Ministry of Power's checklist asks for exactly this.

2. Is it OCPP 1.6J or 2.0.1 compliant, and can I connect it to a different software provider than yours? If the answer is no, you are renting your own business.
3. What is the real output at Indian ambient temperatures, in May, at 45 degrees? Ask for the derating curve.
4. What is the warranty in years, and what is the response time for a fault? Four hours versus four days is the difference between 2 per cent and 10 per cent downtime.
5. What does the AMC cost per year after warranty, and what does it cover? Expect 4 to 8 per cent of the equipment price per year.
6. Is there a local service engineer within 100 km? Get the city, not the promise.
7. What is the spare parts lead time for a power module? This single component causes most long outages.
8. Does the unit meet CEA safety regulations for earthing, residual current protection, lightning protection and enclosure material? Ask for the declaration.
9. What is the payment and settlement flow, and how do I get my money? Some vendors hold settlements for days and some for a month.

> **The 15 per cent rule**
> Price the whole project, not the charger. In most Indian installations the machine is 40 to 55 per cent of the total cost. Upstream electrical work, civil work, approvals and software make up the rest, and they are where budgets actually break.

17. Upstream: transformer, cable, and the LT/HT line

This is the part of the project that surprises everyone. A charger is a load, and a load needs a supply. Three things follow.

The 150 kW line

The Ministry of Power's 2024 guidelines require the distribution licensee to provide a low-tension connection up to 150 kW for charging stations, provided you apply for a separate LT connection for the station. Above that you move to high tension, which means your own transformer and typically a much larger capital number. This is the single best argument for a first station of 60 to 120 kW total rather than 240.

What upstream actually contains

- The distribution transformer, if your load needs one, and the HT or LT cabling to your panel
- AC distribution box, circuit breakers, isolators, surge protection, metering
- Earthing, which in Indian conditions is a real engineering item, not an afterthought
- Mounting structures, foundation or plinth, cable trenching, fencing, shed, bollards, lighting
- Signage, bay marking, and the display of tariff and service charge that the guidelines require

Rough numbers

Station size	Upstream and civil, typical	Total project, typical
6 x 3.3 kW AC (about 20 kW)	Rs 1.2-2.0 lakh	Rs 3.5-5 lakh

Station size	Upstream and civil, typical	Total project, typical
1 x 60 kW DC (about 67 kVA)	Rs 5.5-8.5 lakh	Rs 13-16 lakh
2 x 60 kW DC (about 130 kVA)	Rs 8-12 lakh	Rs 22-28 lakh
2 x 120 kW DC (about 250 kVA)	Rs 12-18 lakh	Rs 34-45 lakh

The spread is wide because it depends on how far the nearest capable transformer is. Before you sign a lease, ask the DISCOM subdivision engineer one question: what is the sanctioned capacity available at this location today? A site with no headroom can add three months and several lakh rupees to your project.

18. Software: the part that quietly decides your revenue

A charger without software is a socket. With software it is a business: it meters, bills, settles, monitors, reports to the government database, and tells you at 11 pm that gun two has been down since 4 pm.

Four things your software must do, in order of importance:

1. Start and stop a session reliably and bill it correctly, with UPI as the default and RFID or app as options. Failed payment attempts are a silent revenue leak that operators consistently underestimate.
2. Publish live status, location, connector type and tariff to the national ecosystem. The Ministry of Power requires public operators to register on the Bureau of Energy Efficiency's national database, the public face of which is the EV Yatra portal, and to share annual energy sold per charger.
3. Support OCPP so you can change software vendors without changing hardware, and OCPI if you want roaming so other networks' customers can pay at your station.
4. Give you a daily report you will actually read: units sold per gun, revenue, downtime minutes, and sessions by hour.

Unified Bharat e-Charge

India's national charging interoperability platform, Unified Bharat e-Charge, was announced by the Ministry of Heavy Industries on 12 May 2026, launched on 15 August 2026 with charging visible inside the BHIM app, and began its pilot across Maharashtra, Karnataka, Delhi-NCR, Haryana and Rajasthan from 3 September 2026. BHEL is the implementation agency, NPCI's BHIM arm built the platform, and the protocol underneath is Beckn, the same open standard ONDC runs on.

For a small operator, the practical meaning is simple: ask your CMS provider whether it can connect to UBC, and if not, whether they have a partner who can. If you are ever in a PM E-DRIVE funded project, onboarding to the National Unified Hub is a condition of the second subsidy tranche, so the answer matters commercially, not just technically.

PART FOUR

Permissions and Power

India has made this easy on purpose. De-licensed does not mean unregulated, and the paperwork is where projects quietly stall.

19. De-licensed: what that means, and what it does not

The Ministry of Power's Guidelines for Installation and Operation of Electric Vehicle Charging Infrastructure, 2024, issued on 17 September 2024, state plainly that setting up and operating EV charging stations is a de-licensed activity and any entity is free to establish charging infrastructure while adhering to the guidelines. PIB has repeated this in Parliament answers through 2026: no licence is needed, and private entrepreneurs can participate.

What that gives you: no power distribution licence, no charging-specific central permit, no entry barrier, and no cap on how many stations you build.

What it does not give you: exemption from electrical safety law, from fire safety, from municipal rules, from GST registration, from metering requirements, from data reporting, or from your lease. In practice you will touch six authorities, and Chapter 42 lists every document for each.

Authority	What they want	Typical timeline
DISCOM	Application, feasibility, demand note payment, metered connection	3 days metro, 7 municipal, 15 rural, 30 hilly; 90 if mains extension needed
State Electrical Inspectorate (CEIG)	Single-line diagram, layout, earthing details, safety clearance before energisation	1-4 weeks, varies by state
Fire department	Fire NOC for public commercial premises in most states	2-6 weeks
Municipal or local body	Trade licence, signage permission, sometimes a site approval	1-3 weeks
State Nodal Agency / BEE	Registration on the national public charging database	Days, once the station is live
GST department	Registration if turnover crosses the threshold; correct SAC on invoices	Same week online

20. The DISCOM process, step by step

The 2024 guidelines turned this into a timed process with a single window, which is a real improvement on what existed before. Here is what should happen, and what to do when it does not.

1. Apply online for a separate metered connection for the charging station. Ask for the EV tariff category explicitly. The application form in the guidelines' annexure asks for location, coordinates, desired load, supply type, charger type and connector count, so have those ready.
2. The DISCOM must scrutinise and revert on discrepancies within 3 days. You then have 3 days to resubmit.
3. Technical feasibility and the demand note follow, within the timelines in the Electricity (Rights of Consumers) Rules, 2020: 3 days in metropolitan areas, 7 in other municipal areas, 15 in rural areas, 30 in hilly terrain, and up to 90 days where distribution mains must be extended or a new substation commissioned.
4. Pay the demand note. For connections up to 150 kW the connection charges must be pre-specified by the state regulator, so ask for the schedule in writing rather than accepting a verbal figure.
5. Get the electrical inspectorate's safety clearance before energisation. The guidelines' standard operating procedure makes this an explicit step: safety clearance is shared by the applicant before the connection is energised.

6 Install and commission, then register the station on the national database.

If the DISCOM misses its timeline, the Electricity (Rights of Consumers) Rules provide for a penalty determined by the state commission. Very few operators invoke it, and you probably will not either, but quoting the rule in a written follow-up changes the tone of the conversation.

> **Keep this in your file**
> The application reference number, the demand note, the sanctioned load letter, the meter seal certificate, the electrical inspector's clearance, and the commissioning report. Six documents. When you sell the business or refinance it, these are the proof that the asset exists and is legal.

21. Your tariff: single part, solar hours, and a 2028 sunset

This is where the government has genuinely tilted the table in your favour, and where most business plans still use the wrong number.

Under the 2024 guidelines, the tariff for electricity supplied to an EV charging station must be single part, with no separate demand charge, and must not exceed the DISCOM's Average Cost of Supply until 31 March 2028. On top of that, the distribution licensee must charge 0.7 times the Average Cost of Supply during solar hours, defined as 9 am to 4 pm, and 1.3 times during the remaining hours.

Read that again, because it is a pricing instruction. Power is 30 per cent cheaper between 9 am and 4 pm and 30 per cent more expensive outside it. If your customers charge at midday, your margin per unit rises by roughly the difference. If they all arrive at 8 pm, you are buying at the peak rate.

Every station must have separate metering to apply this tariff. Behind an existing high-tension connection, the DISCOM may provide sub-metering for the charger.

Hour band	What you pay	Effect on you
9:00 am to 4:00 pm (solar hours)	0.7 x Average Cost of Supply	Cheapest power of the day; push sessions here
4:00 pm to 9:00 am (non-solar)	1.3 x Average Cost of Supply	Most expensive; this is when most customers arrive
Fixed or demand charge	Not applicable: single-part tariff	Removes a fixed cost that used to kill low-utilisation sites

Actual per-unit rates come from your state electricity regulator's tariff order, and they vary widely. Industry estimates in 2026 put the landed cost of power for EV charging somewhere between Rs 6 and Rs 15 a unit depending on state, category and site arrangement. Maharashtra's rates are set by the MERC order of 28 March 2025; Karnataka's by KERC; Tamil Nadu created a dedicated LT-VII and HT-V category for public charging. Do not model your business on another state's number.

22. Service charges: the ceiling, and how to price under it

Your customer's bill has four components, and the guidelines name them: the electricity tariff, passed through per unit; a service charge per unit; land cost, passed through as per the registered land deed; and GST. Two of those you control, and one of them is capped.

The service charge ceilings, excluding GST and land cost, apply until 31 March 2028 to conductive AC and DC charging at public and community stations, whether on public or private land:

Charging type	During solar hours (9 am - 4 pm)	During non-solar hours (4 pm - 9 am)
AC (slow)	Rs 3.00 per unit	Rs 4.00 per unit
DC (fast)	Rs 11.00 per unit	Rs 13.00 per unit

The ceilings are subject to annual review, and a committee under the Central Electricity Authority recommends them from time to time. Stations must prominently display the charging rate per unit and the applicable service charge, which is both a legal requirement and, conveniently, good marketing.

What this means for your price

Take a 60 kW DC station buying power at Rs 9 a unit outside solar hours. Your maximum pre-GST price is Rs 9 plus Rs 13, or Rs 22 a unit, which becomes Rs 25.96 with 18 per cent GST. In solar hours, power at Rs 6.30 and a Rs 11 ceiling gives Rs 17.30 pre-GST, or Rs 20.41 with tax. In practice most public DC chargers in India sit between Rs 15 and Rs 25 a unit including GST, with a median around Rs 18 in September 2026 across a tracker covering nearly 5,800 DC chargers.

Price at the ceiling and you will lose volume to the station 4 km away. Price too low and no utilisation number will save you. The workable strategy is a two-tier price: full rate outside solar hours, a visibly discounted rate from 9 am to 4 pm. You earn more per unit in the cheap window even after the discount, and you flatten your load, which is what your transformer and your patience both want.

23. Reading your first electricity bill

The tariff rules only help you if the bill that arrives reflects them. A surprising number of stations are billed on a commercial category for a year before anyone notices, and the difference is often three to five rupees a unit, which on a 60 kW station is Rs 15,000 to Rs 25,000 a month of margin quietly gone.

Here is the five-minute check, every month.

1. Look at the tariff category printed on the bill. It should name EV charging, or the state's equivalent category, not commercial or industrial. If it does not, that is the conversation to have, in writing.
2. Check that there is no demand charge or fixed charge line, beyond a nominal meter rent. The 2024 guidelines require a single-part tariff. A demand charge on a station that is idle 80 per cent of the day is the single most common reason a viable site looks unviable.
3. Check the rate against the time-of-day structure. If your meter is not configured for the 0.7 times and 1.3 times bands, you are probably paying the flat average cost of supply all day, which is legal but means you are overpaying in the cheap window and underpaying at peak. Ask for time-of-day metering.
4. Check the meter multiplier. A current transformer meter often has a multiplier of 10 or 20, and a misread multiplier turns a Rs 40,000 bill into a Rs 4,00,000 one.
5. Add up electricity duty, cess and any state levy. These sit on top of the tariff and are not covered by the ceiling; budget 5 to 15 per cent depending on state.
6. Reconcile. Units billed this month versus units sold on your CMS. If the gap is above 3 per cent, you either have a metering fault, a theft, or a CMS that is not counting every session. Investigate all three.

> **The letter that works**
> If you are billed on the wrong category, write one page to the subdivision officer: quote clause 9 of the Ministry of Power's Guidelines for Installation and Operation of EV Charging Infrastructure 2024, quote your state regulator's EV tariff order and category number, attach the sanctioned load letter, and ask for reclassification with retrospective adjustment. Send it by registered post and email. It is usually resolved at the subdivision level within a month.

24. Safety: CEIG, and Chapter XI of the CEA regulations

The Central Electricity Authority (Measures relating to Safety and Electric Supply) Regulations, 2023, notified on 8 June 2023, contain a dedicated chapter on EV charging, regulations 123 to 128. This is the text an electrical inspector reads, and it is worth knowing because it is specific.

- Each charging point must be supplied individually by a dedicated sub-circuit, protected by an overcurrent device that is part of a switchboard, not a device somewhere along the cable.
- All protective devices must be coordinated, so a fault trips the nearest device rather than the whole panel.
- Every station needs an earth continuity monitoring system that disconnects the supply if the earthing connection to the vehicle fails.
- Lightning protection is required as per relevant standards, and separate protection against overload of input and output supply.
- Socket outlets for charging must be at least 800 mm above finished ground level.
- A vehicle connector must not be used with an adaptor, and a second supply lead or extension cord is not permitted. Portable socket boards are not allowed for EV charging at all.
- The distance between the charging point and the vehicle's inlet must not exceed 5 metres while charging.
- Only four-core cable for three-phase charging points. Underground cable must avoid crossing the charging area or vehicle passage, and where it must, it runs at least one metre below finished ground.
- The equipment enclosure must be fire retardant, self-extinguishing and halogen-free. Fire detection, alarm and control systems as per relevant standards.
- The owner must carry out the tests specified in the manufacturer's instructions for residual current devices and the station, and keep records of design, construction, labelling, test certificates and every inspection for at least seven years, in hard or electronic form.

Two of these are the ones inspectors actually check first: the earth continuity monitoring, and the seven-year record file. Build the file from day one, in a single folder, with a dated page for every test. Chapter 37 gives you the contents list.

Beyond the CEA rules, most states require the Chief Electrical Inspector to Government, or the state electrical inspectorate, to clear the installation before energisation, and a fire NOC from the state fire department for public commercial premises. Neither is a formality in a station handling 60 kW continuously.

25. Fire NOC, municipal permissions, signage and the database

Four smaller items that each cost a week if you leave them to the end.

Fire NOC

Most states require a no-objection certificate from the fire department for a commercial public charging station before it operates. The application usually needs a site plan, the electrical layout, evidence of fire extinguishers and, for covered stations, detection. Budget two to six weeks and keep the certificate displayed.

Municipal

A trade licence for the commercial activity, signage permission if you are putting up a board over a certain size, and in some cities a separate approval for digging or for a canopy. If your site is on government land, the lease or licence agreement comes first, and the Ministry's model revenue-sharing agreement at Rs 1 per kWh with a 10-year term is the template the land-owning agency will use.

Signage and accessibility

The guidelines' functionality checklist asks for clear instructions in English, Hindi and the local language, charger specifications displayed on the unit, dedicated and unobstructed parking bays, the operator's customer care number alongside 112 and the women's helpline 1091 displayed prominently, and lighting adequate for the site. Madhya Pradesh's 2025 policy goes further and makes accessibility for differently abled users a condition of subsidy disbursement, with nodal agency confirmation required. Design the bays wide and level from the start; retrofitting is expensive.

The national database

The Bureau of Energy Efficiency maintains a national online database of public charging stations, working with state nodal agencies, with open APIs for third-party developers and the EV Yatra portal as its public face. Public operators register using minimal fields and share annual data on energy sold per charger. Registration is free, takes an afternoon, and puts you in front of every driver who uses the portal. Not registering is leaving customers on the table.

PART FIVE

The Money

Capex, margin, payback, GST and the subsidy stack, with the arithmetic shown so you can argue with it.

26. Three station archetypes, costed

Three real configurations, priced at 2026 rates, so you can see where the money goes before you meet a vendor.

Archetype A: the neighbourhood AC hub

Line item	Amount
6 x 3.3 kW AC points, BIS certified	Rs 1,50,000
LT connection, panel, cabling, earthing (about 20 kW)	Rs 1,40,000
Civil, plinth, canopy, signage, bay marking	Rs 70,000
CMS setup and payment integration	Rs 20,000
Approvals, inspectorate, contingency	Rs 40,000
Total	Rs 4,20,000

This is the cheapest entry into the business and the one with the thinnest per-unit margin. It works when the land is already yours, the site has footfall for another reason, or a society or office is paying for the convenience. It rarely works as a standalone rented site, and Chapter 26 shows why in numbers.

Archetype B: the city DC station

Line item	Amount
60 kW DC dual-gun CCS2 charger	Rs 6,10,000
GST on charger at 5 per cent	Rs 30,500
LT connection at about 67 kVA, panel, cabling, earthing, protection	Rs 5,00,000
Civil, foundation, canopy, lighting, signage, bay marking	Rs 1,60,000
CMS setup, integration, testing	Rs 35,000
CEIG clearance, fire NOC, municipal, contingency	Rs 1,60,000
Total	Rs 14,95,500

Round it to Rs 15 lakh. This is the number this playbook uses for every payback calculation, and it is deliberately mid-market: a branded charger and a difficult transformer can push it to Rs 18 lakh, a keen vendor and an easy connection can bring it to Rs 12.5 lakh.

Archetype C: the two-gun highway hub

Line item	Amount
2 x 120 kW DC dual-gun CCS2 chargers	Rs 17,00,000
GST at 5 per cent	Rs 85,000
Transformer, HT connection, cabling, protection (about 250 kVA)	Rs 13,00,000
Civil, canopy, lighting, signage, two food-grade bays	Rs 4,00,000
CMS, integration, payment hardware	Rs 60,000
Approvals, fire, contingency	Rs 2,50,000
Total	Rs 37,95,000

Round it to Rs 38 lakh before land. This is not a first station unless you already own the land and the location, or you have a fleet contract that covers the debt service.

27. The revenue engine, in one equation

Everything reduces to four numbers. Write them on the back of an envelope before any meeting.

> *Monthly profit = (units sold x margin per unit) - fixed costs - payment gateway fees*

Units sold is the only one that moves a lot. Margin per unit is squeezed between your power cost and the service charge ceiling. Fixed costs are known on day one. So the entire business is a bet on units, and units are a function of hours plugged in.

For a 60 kW dual-gun charger, a useful conversion is this: one hour of charging at an average 40 kW draw is 40 units. At Rs 10 of margin per unit, one hour of utilisation a day is worth about Rs 12,000 a month before fixed costs. Ten hours a week of real charging is roughly the difference between a station that pays back in three years and one that never does.

28. Utilisation scenarios and payback

Same 60 kW station, Rs 15 lakh capex, selling at Rs 19 a unit before GST, buying power at Rs 9, Rs 15,400 of fixed monthly costs, and 1.5 per cent payment gateway on revenue. The only thing that changes across the rows is how busy the machine is.

Utilisation	Units/month	Gross margin	Net before EMI and tax	Payback
5% (S&P; Global's 2024 estimate)	1,440	Rs 14,400	Rs -1,410	never
8.7% (median, Nov 2026)	2,506	Rs 25,056	Rs 8,942	14.0 years
18% (viability line)	5,184	Rs 51,840	Rs 34,963	3.6 years
25% (top quartile)	7,200	Rs 72,000	Rs 54,548	2.3 years

Read the first two rows and then read them again. At the sector median, this station pays back in about fourteen years, which is longer than the charger will last and longer than any loan. At 18 per cent it pays back in about three and a half. There is no price, no brand and no subsidy that closes that gap. Only the site does.

The margin sensitivity

Selling price (pre-GST)	Margin per unit	Net per month at 18%	Payback
Rs 17 per unit	Rs 8	Rs 24,750	5.1 years
Rs 19 per unit	Rs 10	Rs 34,963	3.6 years
Rs 21 per unit	Rs 12	Rs 45,175	2.8 years

Two rupees of price is worth about eight months of payback. That is why the solar-hour discount is worth running: it is not a discount at all, it is a lower purchase price on the same unit, and it moves your

average margin up rather than down.

The AC hub, honestly

The archetype A hub, six AC points, average 2.5 kW draw, 30 per cent utilisation, selling at Rs 12 and buying at Rs 8, produces about 3,240 units a month and nets about Rs 4,877 a month before EMI. On Rs 4.2 lakh that is a payback of roughly 7 years. It is not a bad business. It is a convenience business: it makes sense when the land is free, the footfall is already there, and the alternative is an empty parking bay.

> **The threshold, in one line**
> Do not build a station you cannot show, on paper and with a site visit, clearing 18 per cent utilisation within 12 months of opening. If it only works at 25 per cent, it is not a plan, it is a hope.

29. Three sites, three outcomes

The same model, run on three real site types. Note how little the charger matters and how much the site does.

Site one: the highway forecourt

Two 120 kW dual-gun chargers, 240 kW installed, Rs 38 lakh before land, power at Rs 9, sold at Rs 19, fixed costs of Rs 1.5 lakh a month once you count rent, an attendant, AMC and marketing. At 26 per cent utilisation, which is what a genuinely good highway site does, the station sells about 37,400 units a month and nets roughly Rs 2.1 lakh before EMI and tax. Payback on the equipment: about 18 months.

At 12 per cent, the same station sells 17,280 units and nets only about Rs 18,000 a month, because the Rs 1.5 lakh of fixed costs does not shrink with the traffic. Payback stretches past fifteen years. The difference between those two outcomes is roughly 15 cars a day. That is what highway frontage is worth, and it is why the good ones are not cheap.

Site two: the mall basement

One 60 kW dual-gun charger, Rs 15 lakh, power at Rs 9, sold at Rs 20 because destination customers are less price-sensitive, but Rs 25,000 a month to the mall for the two bays. At 12 per cent utilisation, which is realistic for a mall without a fleet anchor, the station nets about Rs 12,000 a month. Payback: over ten years. It does not work as an owned asset.

Now flip the structure. If the mall buys the charger and you operate it for a management fee plus a share of revenue, the mall earns a return on its own real estate and you earn a fee with no capital at risk. Same site, same machine, completely different business. This is why Chapter 4 started with the host model.

Site three: the e-rickshaw stand

Four 3.3 kW AC points plus one 12 kW light-EV DC unit, about 25 kW installed, Rs 5 lakh all in, power at Rs 8, sold at Rs 13, fixed costs of Rs 9,000 a month. E-rickshaw drivers charge daily and queue at fixed hours, so 35 per cent utilisation is achievable with an attendant who manages the queue.

That station sells about 4,500 units a month, nets about Rs 12,800, and pays back in roughly three years. Lower revenue than either of the others, far lower capital, and the most predictable demand of the three, because the same forty drivers come back every single day.

	Highway 2 x 120 kW	Mall 1 x 60 kW	E-rickshaw 25 kW
Capex	Rs 38 lakh	Rs 15 lakh	Rs 5 lakh
Utilisation	26%	12%	35%
Units/month	37,440	3,456	4,536
Net before EMI	Rs 2.1 lakh	Rs 12,000	Rs 12,800
Payback	about 18 months	over 10 years	about 3 years
Biggest risk	Downtime, and land cost	Bay blocking, no anchor fleet	Queue chaos, thin margin

> **The pattern**
> Capital efficiency beats absolute revenue. The e-rickshaw stand earns a sixth of the highway hub but pays back in a fifth of the time, and its demand is contractual in all but name. If you have Rs 5 lakh and no land, that is the station to build.

30. Operating costs people forget

Cost head	Typical monthly	Note
Site rent or revenue share	Rs 5,000-40,000	Or Rs 1-3 per unit sold; the largest single fixed cost
Electricity fixed or demand charges	Rs 0-8,000	Single-part tariff should remove most of this; verify your bill
AMC and maintenance	Rs 2,000-8,000	Budget 4-8 per cent of equipment cost per year
CMS or software subscription	Rs 500-1,500 per charger	Plus per-transaction fees in some models
Payment gateway	1-2% of revenue	Silent, and larger than most operators expect
Insurance	Rs 1,000-3,000	Equipment and public liability
Connectivity and SIM	Rs 300-800	Never skip this; without it you are blind
Consumables, cleaning, cable wear	Rs 500-1,500	Cables and guns are the parts that fail first
Staff or attendant	Rs 0-35,000	Needed above four chargers, or for 2W/3W sites
Marketing and signage	Rs 1,000-5,000	Google Business Profile is free and does most of the work

The maintenance line is the one to argue about. Industry estimates put annual maintenance at 5 to 10 per cent of capex, which on a Rs 15 lakh station is Rs 75,000 to Rs 1.5 lakh a year, or Rs 6,000 to Rs 12,500 a month. Vendors quote AMC at the low end because AMC rarely covers the power module. Add a sinking fund of Rs 40,000 a year for a module replacement in year four.

31. GST: 18 per cent out, and the input credit nobody claims

You charge 18 per cent GST on the full value of the charging service, energy included, under SAC 998714. You claim input tax credit on what you bought: the charger at 5 per cent, the civil and electrical work at 18 per cent, the software, the AMC, the rent if your landlord charges GST.

The credit on the charger is small because the charger is taxed at 5 per cent. The credit on the electrical and civil work is the one that matters, and it is frequently lost because the work is paid for in cash to a contractor who does not bill it. Get a proper tax invoice for the whole upstream package. On a Rs 6 lakh electrical contract that is Rs 1.08 lakh of credit, which is real money against a station's first-year profit.

Two more points. If your turnover is below the GST registration threshold you may not need to register, but you then cannot claim any credit, and you will have to register the moment you cross it, so most operators register from day one. And if you run the station as a proprietorship, keep the business current account separate from the first month, because every subsidy application and every loan will ask for three years of it.

> **The invoice line that matters**
> Show the tariff, the service charge and the GST as separate lines on the customer's receipt. It is required, it is what the guidelines call transparent pricing, and it is the only defence you have if a customer or an inspector disputes the bill.

32. Financing and the subsidy stack

What the centre actually offers

PM E-DRIVE, approved on 29 September 2024 with an outlay of Rs 10,900 crore, sets aside Rs 2,000 crore for public charging infrastructure and targets around 72,300 public charging stations. The operational guidelines issued on 26 September 2025 define four location categories and their support:

Category	Location	Support
A	State or central government premises, open to the public without restriction	100% of upstream infrastructure and 100% of charger cost
B	Government-controlled public places: railway and metro stations, airports, state bus stations, municipal parking, public sector fuel pumps, NHAI toll plazas and wayside amenities	80% of upstream infrastructure, 70% of charger cost
C	Everything else: streets, malls, markets, private highway land	80% of upstream infrastructure only
D	Battery swapping and battery charging stations, any location	80% of upstream infrastructure only

And the sentence that decides whether this matters to you: eligible entities are government ministries, central public sector enterprises, states and union territories and their PSUs. A private owner cannot apply directly. PIB confirmed on 27 March 2026 that no funds had yet been released for EV public charging stations under PM E-DRIVE, with the entire Rs 2,000 crore still unspent as of 24 March 2026.

The realistic private route is to be the charge point operator a government agency or a public sector oil company engages through a tender, or to host on land they control. Be sceptical of anyone offering to arrange a PM E-DRIVE subsidy for your private site for a fee.

What the states actually offer

This is where private money gets help. Five state policies, read from the notified documents:

State and policy	What a charging station gets	Conditions
Madhya Pradesh EV Policy 2025	30% of charger cost: up to Rs 1.5 lakh for small stations (first 500), Rs 3 lakh for medium (first 300), Rs 10 lakh for large (first 200). Battery swapping: 30% up to Rs 5 lakh (first 300).	Apply on the EV Tarang portal; physical verification before disbursement; accessibility compliance required
Maharashtra EV Policy 2025 (1 Apr 2025 - 31 Mar 2030)	Viability gap funding of up to 15% of station cost: Rs 5 lakh per station for DC 50-250 kW (first 1,000, minimum 4 charging points), Rs 10 lakh for 250-500 kW (first 500, minimum 2 points)	Station cost only, excluding land and ancillary; MERC order of 28 Mar 2025 sets the concessional tariff
Tamil Nadu EV Policy 2023	25% of equipment and machinery cost: up to Rs 10 lakh for public fast charging stations (first 200), Rs 1 lakh for slow (first 500), Rs 2 lakh for battery swapping (first 200)	Land cost excluded; rooftop solar counts as equipment if 75% of generation is used on site
Uttar Pradesh EV Policy 2022	20% capital subsidy up to Rs 10 lakh per station for the first 2,000, and up to Rs 5 lakh for swapping stations (first 1,000)	Minimum Rs 25 lakh investment for charging, Rs 15 lakh for swapping; government land at Rs 1/kWh for 10 years
Karnataka Clean Mobility Policy 2025-30	25% capital subsidy up to Rs 10 lakh per fast charging station (first 500); no incentive for slow charging; swapping up to Rs 3 lakh for 2W/3W, Rs 5 lakh for cars, Rs 10 lakh for buses	BESCOM is the nodal agency; single window through BESCOM

Other states run schemes at different stages of life: Haryana, Rajasthan, Punjab, Andhra Pradesh, Kerala, Gujarat, Delhi, Telangana, Bihar and West Bengal have all notified something since 2021, and several have let their charging incentives lapse. Never rely on a blog summary, including this table, for a state not listed above. Check the state EV policy PDF on the state nodal agency site, then phone the nodal agency and ask one question: how many slots under this head are still unclaimed?

> **The five questions to ask your state nodal agency**
>
> Is the policy still in force, and on what date does it lapse? What exactly does the incentive cover, equipment only or the whole station? Is there a minimum investment or minimum number of charging points? How many stations have already claimed this head? What documents do you need, and when do you pay, before commissioning or after?

33. The 2028 sunset, and how to plan for it

Three of the protections this playbook relies on have an end date: 31 March 2028. The single-part tariff capped at the average cost of supply, the 0.7 and 1.3 time-of-day multipliers, and the service charge ceilings all run until then, and the ceilings are in any case subject to annual review by a Central Electricity Authority committee.

Nobody can tell you what the regime looks like on 1 April 2028. What you can do is make sure your business does not depend on the answer.

1. Model a stress case with power 30 per cent more expensive and the service charge ceiling removed. If the station still clears its costs at 18 per cent utilisation, you have a business. If it only works under today's rules, you have a five-year trade.

2. Never sign a customer contract with a fixed price for longer than 24 months without a tariff pass-through clause. This is the single most common way small operators get trapped: a three-year fixed rate to a fleet, followed by a tariff revision.
3. Write the sunset into your loan tenor. A seven-year loan on an asset whose margin structure is guaranteed for eighteen months is a bet on regulation, not on charging.
4. Keep the solar option open. The 9 am to 4 pm discount exists because the grid wants daytime load; that logic survives 2028 even if the exact multiplier changes.
5. Watch the annual review. The ceilings are reviewed every year, and a downward revision is the one regulatory change that can hurt you immediately. If you hear of a CEA consultation on service charges, read it and respond. Operators who comment are rare and are listened to.

The upside case is just as worth planning for. If the network stays thin and EV sales keep compounding at anything like the 2026 pace, an installed station in a good location becomes a scarcer asset every year, and the tariff regime is more likely to be extended than tightened. Build for the downside, and the upside takes care of itself.

34. The cash-flow trap in year one

A station that is profitable on paper can still kill you in month seven, and the reason is always the same: the money arrives after the costs do.

- Month 1 to 3 is capex. Everything goes out. The demand note, the civil contractor, the charger's advance, the electrician.
- Month 3 to 6 is commissioning. The DISCOM connection, the inspector's clearance, the fire NOC. Revenue is zero and rent is running.
- Month 6 to 12 is ramp. Utilisation typically starts at a third of steady state and climbs as drivers discover you. Your fixed costs are at full strength from day one.
- Subsidy, if you get one, is usually disbursed after commissioning and physical verification, often a quarter or two later.

Two practical defences. First, keep a working capital reserve of six months of fixed costs plus one month of your EMI, in cash, before you open. On a Rs 15 lakh station that is roughly Rs 1.5 lakh. Second, negotiate the charger payment in three tranches: advance, on delivery, and 20 per cent retained for 60 days after commissioning, tied to the uptime guarantee. A vendor who will not accept a retention has told you something about their confidence in the unit.

PART SIX

Run It

Pricing, uptime, fleets, add-ons and the boring systems that decide whether year two looks like year one.

35. Pricing strategy inside a ceiling

You have three levers and one constraint. The levers are your base rate, your time-of-day discount, and your idle fee. The constraint is the service charge ceiling until 31 March 2028.

1. Set the base rate at the local market rate, not at the ceiling. Look up the three nearest chargers, note their price, and sit at or slightly below the median. Undercutting by 40 per cent buys you nothing because your customers are choosing on location and reliability.
2. Run a genuine solar-hour rate from 9 am to 4 pm. Your power is 30 per cent cheaper in that window, so a 15 to 20 per cent discount still leaves you better off per unit than a full-price sale at 8 pm, and it spreads your load.
3. Charge an idle fee after 90 minutes of a completed session. Rs 2 per minute after a 30-minute grace period is common. This one policy raises revenue per bay more than any price increase, because it converts a blocked bay into a paying session.
4. Offer a fleet card: a fixed rate per unit, monthly invoicing, a minimum offtake, and a reserved window. Fleet rates are typically 8 to 15 per cent below retail and worth every rupee because they are contracted.

Display everything. The guidelines require the charging rate and the service charge to be prominently displayed, and in practice a driver who cannot see the price before plugging in assumes the worst.

36. Uptime is a revenue line

The November 2026 tracking of 1,745 public DC stations found the median station out of action 2 per cent of the time and the average station more than 10 per cent. The gap between those two numbers is entirely operational, and it is worth more than most price changes.

A station down 10 per cent of the time loses 10 per cent of its revenue and, worse, trains its customers to go somewhere else. Reliability compounds in both directions.

The routine that produces 2 per cent

- Daily, remotely: check every gun's status, the last session, and the error log. Five minutes.
- Weekly, on site: inspect cables and guns for cuts and bent pins, clean the screen, test the emergency stop, check the bay markings, look for water ingress.
- Monthly: torque-check the connections, test the earth continuity monitoring, photograph the meter reading, reconcile units sold against units bought. A gap above 3 per cent means theft or a metering fault.
- Quarterly: a proper electrical inspection against the CEA checklist, and a fire extinguisher service.
- Always: a local person within 20 minutes who can reset the unit, and a phone number that a human answers.

Keep a downtime log from day one, with the fault, the time reported, the time fixed and who fixed it. Two uses: it is your warranty evidence, and it is the single most persuasive document when you negotiate an AMC renewal or sell the business.

37. Win fleets before you win the public

The fastest route from 6 per cent to 18 per cent utilisation is not marketing. It is one contract.

India's electric three-wheeler penetration reached 61 per cent of all three-wheeler sales in FY2025-26, and electric two-wheeler penetration crossed 9.6 per cent in October 2026. Those vehicles belong to fleets, aggregators and individual drivers who run 100 to 150 km a day and charge once or twice. They are the most reliable customers in the country and they are reachable in person.

Who to approach, in order

1. The e-rickshaw union or stand nearest your site. Twenty drivers charging once a day at 6 kWh is 120 kWh a day, every day, at a predictable hour.
2. Last-mile delivery hubs. Every dark-store, courier branch and food-delivery cluster has a fixed number of EVs and a supervisor who hates charging chaos.
3. App-based cab operators running electric sedans. They need a reliable DC point and will pay a premium for a reserved slot.
4. School and staff bus operators. A 40-seat electric bus needs a 240 kW charger and a contract; this is the big one if you have the site and the capital.
5. Corporate campuses and hospitals with staff EVs. A workplace charging arrangement is often a facilities decision, not a procurement one, and moves faster than you expect.

38. The fleet pitch and the terms that protect you

One page, four numbers, one ask. Here is the shape of it.

> **Pitch structure**
> Line 1: who you are and where the station is, in one sentence. Line 2: your uptime record or your guarantee, because that is what a fleet manager actually fears. Line 3: the rate per unit and what it includes. Line 4: the reserved window you can offer and the minimum offtake you need. Line 5: the ask, which is a 20-minute meeting at the site.

Contract terms worth insisting on:

- A minimum monthly offtake, expressed in units, with a shortfall charge. Without it you have given away a reserved window for free.
- Payment within 15 days, with a security deposit of one month's average billing.
- A rate review every 12 months, linked to your electricity tariff, so a tariff revision does not silently destroy your margin.
- A term of at least 24 months, with 60 days' notice for either side after that.
- Clarity on who pays for damage to cables and guns, which is the most common dispute in fleet charging.

One caution on exclusivity. A fleet will often ask you not to serve its competitors at the same site. Refuse politely. Your station's value is its traffic, and a single-fleet site is a single point of failure.

39. Battery swapping as an add-on

Battery swapping makes sense where the vehicle cannot afford to wait: e-rickshaws on double shifts, delivery two-wheelers, and any fleet where the battery is the bottleneck. The Ministry of Power issued separate guidelines for battery swapping and charging stations on 10 January 2025, and they are more permissive than the charging rules in one useful way: owners of a swapping or battery charging station may use an existing electricity connection, with or without seeking an increase in connected load, for charging the swappable batteries.

What that means practically: a swap station can piggyback on a connection you already have, which removes the single biggest source of delay in a new charging project. Industry estimates put the power requirement for a swap station at roughly 30 to 80 kW including ancillary equipment.

The standards are IS 17896 Part 1 and Part 2 (2022) for battery swap systems, general guidance and safety requirements. PM E-DRIVE treats battery swapping stations as category D, with 80 per cent support on upstream infrastructure, though with the same restriction that only government and public sector entities can apply.

The honest caveat: swapping only works if the batteries are interoperable, which in India means committing to one manufacturer's pack standard. That is a supply chain decision, not a charging decision. Do not add swapping to a station unless a fleet has already asked for it in writing.

40. Solar, storage, and the 9-to-4 window

The tariff design in the 2024 guidelines is an explicit invitation: power is 30 per cent cheaper between 9 am and 4 pm, and the service charge ceiling is lower in the same window, which tells you the regulator expects daytime charging to be the cheap, encouraged behaviour. Two ways to exploit it.

Sell into the window

Discount the daytime rate, put a board outside saying so, and talk to fleets about a midday slot. This costs nothing and is the highest-return action in this chapter.

Generate into the window

A rooftop solar array sized to your daytime load cuts the effective cost of the cheapest hours further. Tamil Nadu's policy counts rooftop solar as eligible equipment for its 25 per cent capital subsidy provided at least 75 per cent of the generation is used by the charging station, which is a useful precedent to quote in other states. Size the array to daytime consumption, not to the roof, and do not expect net metering to save a bad site.

Battery storage is a different question. At current Indian prices it rarely pays for a single station unless you are arbitraging a large peak-tariff difference or providing demand response. It becomes interesting at three or more stations, where you can shift load across sites. Park it until you have two stations running well.

41. Staffing, safety and the compliance file

Below four chargers you can run a station alone with a remote CMS and a local electrician on call. Above four, and at any site serving two- and three-wheelers, you need a person on site: someone to guide a first-time user, keep the bays clear, take cash if you accept it, and reset a unit at 9 pm.

The two-page site SOP

1. Before plugging in: confirm the connector matches, check the cable and gun for damage, confirm the vehicle is switched off.
2. During: never pull a gun under load; if a session fails, retry once, then move the vehicle to another gun and log it.
3. After: return the gun to its holster, not the ground. A gun on the ground is the most common cause of water damage.
4. Emergency: the emergency stop is at the unit; the main breaker is at the panel; the fire extinguisher is at the marked point; call 112 first, then the operator.
5. Daily close: meter reading, cash reconciliation if any, fault log, bay inspection, photograph of the site.

The compliance file

One physical folder and one cloud folder, same contents. The CEA regulations require records to be kept for at least seven years, and a subsidy or a sale will ask for all of it.

Document	Why it matters
DISCOM application, demand note, sanctioned load letter	Proves the connection is legal and correctly categorised
Meter seal certificate and first meter reading	The baseline for every unit reconciliation
Electrical inspector's safety clearance	The document an inspector asks for first
Fire NOC	Required to operate a public commercial station in most states
Trade licence and municipal permissions	Protects you from a closure notice
Charger type test certificates and warranty documents	Warranty claims and any subsidy verification
Earthing and insulation test reports, dated	CEA regulation 128 requires records of every test
Downtime log and maintenance log	AMC renewal, warranty, and sale due diligence
GST registration and filed returns	Subsidy and loan applications
Station registration on the national database	Compliance, and free customer discovery

42. Scaling to site two, and how to sell

The second station is where most small operators either become a business or discover that the first one was a hobby. Three tests before you commit capital again.

1. Station one must be above 20 per cent utilisation for three consecutive months without you standing at the gate. If it only works because you are there, it is a job.
2. You must be able to run station one from a phone in under 20 minutes a day. If not, fix the systems before adding a site.

3 The second site should be a different type from the first, not a clone. If site one is a city DC station, site two should be a fleet depot or a destination. Concentrating all your capital in one demand pattern is the mistake large operators made at scale.

When you eventually sell, buyers will value the business on three things: the contracted fleet revenue, the utilisation history, and the length and terms of your land agreements. Which is another way of saying that everything in this playbook that felt like administration was actually asset building. A station with a clean compliance file, a documented uptime record and a two-year fleet contract is worth several times one without, even at identical revenue.

PART SEVEN

Worksheets and Answers

Print these pages. Fill them in before you sign anything.

43. Worksheet: capex estimator

Fill the right column for your site. The left column is a worked example of a 60 kW city station so you can see the scale.

Item	Example (Rs)	Your site (Rs)
Charger hardware, including 5% GST	6,40,500	
Transformer, if required	0	
LT or HT connection charges and demand note	1,20,000	
Cabling, panel, breakers, protection	2,60,000	
Earthing and lightning protection	45,000	
Civil: foundation, plinth, canopy, trenching	1,10,000	
Lighting, signage, bay marking, bollards	50,000	
CMS setup and payment integration	35,000	
CEIG clearance, fire NOC, municipal, legal	90,000	
Working capital reserve (6 months fixed costs)	95,000	
Contingency at 8 per cent	1,20,000	
TOTAL	15,65,500	

44. Worksheet: payback calculator

Six inputs, one output. Use your own site's numbers, not the example's.

Input	Example	Yours
Total capex (from worksheet 39)	Rs 15,00,000	
Charger capacity, kW	60	
Average power drawn while charging, kW	40	
Assumed utilisation, per cent of 24 hours	18%	
Selling price per unit, pre-GST	Rs 19	
Power purchase cost per unit	Rs 9	
Fixed monthly costs (rent, AMC, CMS, insurance, staff)	Rs 15,400	

Then: units per month = average draw x 24 x utilisation x 30. Gross margin = units x (price minus power cost). Net = gross margin minus fixed costs minus 1.5 per cent of revenue. Payback in months = capex divided by net. If the answer is above 60 months, do not proceed until the site or the price changes.

Scenario	Units/month	Net/month	Payback
Pessimistic: 8% utilisation	2,304	Rs 6,980	17.9 years
Base: 18% utilisation	5,184	Rs 34,960	3.6 years
Good: 25% utilisation	7,200	Rs 54,500	2.3 years

Scenario	Units/month	Net/month	Payback
Excellent: 32% utilisation	9,216	Rs 74,100	1.7 years

45. Worksheet: vendor comparison

Question	Vendor A	Vendor B	Vendor C
Model and rated kW			
Price, ex-GST			
GST rate stated			
IS 17017 type test certificate seen?			
NABL lab named on the certificate			
OCPP version, and can I use another CMS?			
Output at 45 degrees ambient			
Warranty, years			
AMC per year after warranty			
Fault response time, hours			
Nearest service engineer, city			
Power module lead time			
CEA safety declarations provided?			
Payment and settlement terms			
Retention offered (aim for 20% for 60 days)			

46. Worksheet: approvals checklist

Step	Authority	Done
Site lease or licence signed, 5+ years	Landowner	
Load availability confirmed in writing	DISCOM subdivision	
Connection application filed, reference number noted	DISCOM	
Demand note received and paid	DISCOM	
Single-line diagram and earthing layout prepared	Your contractor	
Safety clearance before energisation	State electrical inspectorate	
Fire NOC	State fire department	
Trade licence and signage permission	Municipal body	
GST registration and correct SAC on invoices	GST department	
Station registered on the national database	State nodal agency / BEE	
Tariff and service charge displayed at site	You	
Customer care number, 112 and 1091 displayed	You	
Uptime and downtime log started	You	

47. The 90-day launch plan

Days	What gets done
1-10	Site shortlist of five. Count traffic at each on a weekday and a Saturday. Score them on the site scorecard. Pick one, or walk away.
11-20	Negotiate the lease or revenue share. Confirm load availability with the DISCOM engineer in writing. Open the file for compliance documents.
21-30	Apply for the connection. Get three vendor quotes and ask the nine questions. Ask the state nodal agency about the current subsidy and how many slots remain.
31-45	Place the charger order with a retention clause. Award the electrical and civil work on a proper tax invoice. File the fire NOC application.
46-60	Civil and electrical work. Apply for the electrical inspectorate clearance. Set up the CMS, payment flow and GST invoicing.
61-75	Commission. Test every gun with a real vehicle. Register on the national database. Set up the Google Business Profile and photograph the site.
76-90	Open with a fleet contract, not a launch party. Call every e-rickshaw stand, delivery hub and cab operator within 5 km. Start the downtime log. Review units and utilisation every Monday from here on.

48. Twenty questions people actually ask

How much does it cost to start?

A neighbourhood AC hub for two- and three-wheelers: Rs 3.5 to Rs 5 lakh. A single 60 kW city DC station: Rs 13 to Rs 16 lakh. A two-gun 120 kW highway station: Rs 34 to Rs 45 lakh before land. The machine is roughly half the project; the electrical and civil work is the rest.

Do I need a licence?

No. Setting up and operating a charging station is a de-licensed activity under the Ministry of Power's 2024 guidelines, and PIB has confirmed this repeatedly. You do need electrical safety clearance, fire NOC, municipal permissions and a metered connection.

How much can I earn per month?

From the model in Chapter 26: a 60 kW station at the sector median utilisation nets about Rs 9,000 a month. At 18 per cent it nets about Rs 35,000. At 25 per cent, about Rs 55,000. The machine is identical in all three cases.

What is a realistic payback?

Two to four years at a good site, which means 18 per cent utilisation or better. Six years or more at a mediocre one. At the median utilisation measured across India in November 2026, it never pays back.

Can I get the PM E-DRIVE subsidy?

Not directly, if you are a private owner. PM E-DRIVE's Rs 2,000 crore for public charging is open only to government ministries, central public sector enterprises, states and their PSUs. Your realistic route is a state policy, or a contract with one of those entities.

Which state gives the best subsidy?

On paper, Madhya Pradesh at 30 per cent of charger cost up to Rs 10 lakh for large stations, Maharashtra at 15 per cent up to Rs 10 lakh for high-power stations, Karnataka and Tamil Nadu at 25 per cent up to Rs 10 lakh, and Uttar Pradesh at 20 per cent up to Rs 10 lakh. All are capped by station counts and first-come rules, so the answer that matters is how many slots are left.

AC or DC?

DC if the driver waits. AC if the vehicle parks for two hours or more. In India, 91 per cent of EVs are two- and three-wheelers, so the honest answer for most sites is light-EV DC up to 12 kW, not a car fast charger.

How much does electricity cost me?

It varies by state, but industry estimates in 2026 put it between Rs 6 and Rs 15 a unit. The national rule is a single-part tariff at or below the DISCOM's average cost of supply, at 0.7 times that in the 9 am to 4 pm window and 1.3 times outside it, until 31 March 2028.

Can I charge whatever I like per unit?

No. Until 31 March 2028 the service charge is capped at Rs 3 (AC, solar hours) and Rs 4 (AC, non-solar), Rs 11 (DC, solar) and Rs 13 (DC, non-solar) per unit, excluding GST and land cost, on top of the pass-through electricity tariff.

How much GST do I charge?

18 per cent on the full charging service, under SAC 998714, as held by the Karnataka AAR in 2023. The charger itself attracts 5 per cent when you buy it.

What if the charger breaks?

That is the business risk that matters most. The average station in the November 2026 tracking was down more than 10 per cent of the time while the median was at 2 per cent. Buy a warranty with a stated response time, keep a spare power module budget, and have a local electrician who can attend within an hour.

Do I need staff?

Below four chargers, no, provided you have remote monitoring and a local person on call. Above four, or at any two- and three-wheeler site, one attendant pays for themselves in bay turnover and first-time user support.

Can I run it from another city?

Yes, with three conditions: live monitoring with fault alerts, a named local person with a key and a phone number, and a monthly site visit. Without all three, do not.

Is a highway site better than a city site?

Better revenue per unit and better utilisation when the location is right, but higher capex, higher power requirement and no tolerance for downtime. A dead charger on a highway is a customer lost permanently.

Should I add battery swapping?

Only if a fleet asks for it in writing. Swapping locks you into one battery standard and adds a supply chain you do not control. The 2025 guidelines do make it easier by allowing an existing connection to be used.

What about solar?

Worth it if sized to daytime load, because your cheapest power window is 9 am to 4 pm. Not worth it as a substitute for a good site. Tamil Nadu counts rooftop solar toward its equipment subsidy if 75 per cent of generation is used on site.

How do I get discovered?

Register on the national public charging database so you appear on the EV Yatra portal, list on Google Maps with photos and live hours, and tell every fleet within 5 km. Those three are free and do most of the work.

What kills most stations?

A cheap site with no passing EV traffic, followed by downtime, followed by a rent that assumed a busy station from month one. In that order.

Can I sell the business later?

Yes, and it is valued on contracted fleet revenue, documented utilisation history and land agreement terms. Keep the records and the contracts clean from day one.

What is the single most useful number to track?

Units sold per gun per day. Not revenue, not sessions, not app downloads. Units per gun per day tells you instantly whether the site is working.

49. Glossary

Term	What it means in practice
ACoS	Average Cost of Supply. The DISCOM's average cost per unit; EV tariffs are capped at it until 31 March 2028, with a 0.7 multiplier in solar hours and 1.3 outside.
BEE	Bureau of Energy Efficiency, under the Ministry of Power. Runs the national public charging database, the EV Yatra portal, and publishes the benchmark costs used for subsidy calculation.
CCS2	The DC fast-charging connector standard for cars and heavier vehicles in India, IS 17017-2-3.
CEA	Central Electricity Authority. Its 2023 safety regulations, clauses 123 to 128, govern EV charging installations.
CEIG	Chief Electrical Inspector to Government, the state authority that clears your installation before energisation.
CMS	Charger Management System. The software that runs sessions, billing, monitoring and reporting.
CPO	Charge Point Operator. The entity operating the station, which is you.
DISCOM	The distribution company that supplies your electricity and sets your connection timeline.
EVSE	Electric Vehicle Supply Equipment. The charger itself, including its guns.
LEV DC	Light Electric Vehicle DC, up to 12 kW, the fast-charging standard for two- and three-wheelers, IS 17017-2-6.

Term	What it means in practice
OCPP / OCPI	Open protocols for charger-to-software communication (OCPP) and network-to-network roaming (OCPI). Buy OCPP-compliant hardware.
PM E-DRIVE	The central scheme approved on 29 September 2024 with Rs 10,900 crore, of which Rs 2,000 crore is for public charging. Open only to government and public sector entities.
SAC 998714	The service accounting code under which EV charging is classified for GST at 18 per cent.
SNA	State Nodal Agency, the state body that coordinates charging rollout and often disburses state subsidies.
UBC	Unified Bharat e-Charge, the national charging interoperability platform announced in May 2026 and launched in August 2026.
Utilisation	The share of time a charger is delivering paid energy. The single number that determines whether the station works.

50. Sources

Every figure in this playbook is traceable to the following documents, all read in the first week of November 2026. Where a number comes from industry tracking rather than a government source, the text says so.

- Ministry of Power, Guidelines for Installation and Operation of Electric Vehicle Charging Infrastructure 2024, No. 12/2/2018-EV, 17 September 2024. Tariffs, service charge ceilings, connection timelines, land revenue sharing, safety and functionality checklists, national database.
- Ministry of Heavy Industries, Operational Guidelines for Deployment of EV Public Charging Stations under PM E-DRIVE, 26 September 2025. Scheme outlay, eligible entities, location categories, subsidy percentages, BEE benchmark costs of August 2022.
- PM E-DRIVE scheme approval, Gazette notification S.O. 4259(E), 29 September 2024, outlay Rs 10,900 crore.
- PIB releases: 27 March 2026 (de-licensed activity, PM E-DRIVE funds released status), 21 July 2026 (52,718 public charging stations, 16,561 with fast car chargers), 9 December 2025 (subsidy categories), 12 May 2026 (Unified Bharat e-Charge announcement).
- PIB, Roads Reimagined: The Rise of India's Electric Vehicles Ecosystem, 5 August 2026. EV penetration 8.26 per cent in FY2025-26 against 0.08 per cent in FY2015-16.
- Ministry of Power, Guidelines for Installation and Operation of Battery Swapping and Battery Charging Stations, 10 January 2025.
- Central Electricity Authority (Measures relating to Safety and Electric Supply) Regulations 2023, notified 8 June 2023, regulations 123 to 128.
- GST Authority for Advance Rulings, Karnataka, order KAR ADRG 24/2023 dated 13 July 2023, on battery charging as a supply of service under SAC 998714 at 18 per cent.
- Vahan registration data as reported by Autocar Professional (6 April 2026, FY2026 segment splits and penetration), EVreporter (3 November 2026, October 2026 registrations and the twelve-month total) and The Hindu BusinessLine (1 November 2026, monthly penetration).
- Economic Times, 5 November 2026, on EVs reaching 10.7 per cent of 2026 sales.

- SBI report on e-mobility and charging infrastructure, April 2026, and S&P; Global 2024, both on utilisation, as reported by Fortune India on 1 September 2026 and in Vayana's Rubix sectoral insight of September 2026.
- Charge point operator utilisation tracking of 1,745 public DC stations, 30 days to 1 November 2026, published by Zevpoint.
- Business Standard, 10 November 2025, on host-owned charging models and 18 to 20 per cent network utilisation.
- State policies: Madhya Pradesh EV Policy 2025 (Urban Development and Housing Department, EV Tarang portal); Maharashtra EV Policy 2025, Government Resolution MVR-0125/C.R.13/Tra-2 dated 23 May 2025; Tamil Nadu EV Policy 2023 (Industries, Investment Promotion and Commerce Department); Uttar Pradesh EV Manufacturing and Mobility Policy 2022 (Invest UP); Karnataka Clean Mobility Policy 2025-30, Government Order CI 117 SPI 2024(e) dated 11 February 2025.
- Manufacturer and seller list prices, November 2026: Zevpoint, Servotech, Bolt.Earth, Havells, Massive Charging, Charget, TeslaVolts.

A last word

The people who lose money in this business are not the ones who chose the wrong charger. They are the ones who chose a site because it was cheap and then spent three years explaining the numbers to themselves. Do the traffic count. Score the site. Walk away from anything under 60. The rest is engineering, and engineering can be bought.

The numbers to remember

18 per cent utilisation is the line between a business and a donation.

One hour of charging a day is about Rs 12,000 a month of gross margin.

91 per cent of India's EVs are two- and three-wheelers. Buy for them.

Power is 30 per cent cheaper from 9 am to 4 pm. Sell into that window.

The median charger in India is idle 91 per cent of the day. Your job is to be the exception.